'OTHERS TRIED TO SPEAK OUT, BUT THEY PAID A PRICE'

Olympic medallist Sakshi Malik, one of the several wrestlers demanding action against Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, on rumours about the protests being politically driven, why it took so long to take a stand, and why women's representation in federations matters



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Q. Some cast doubt on the allegations of the wrestlers and question the intent behind the protest, saying it's at the behest of a political party.

We are not aligned with any party nor have we been lured by anyone. The aim of the protest was that the allegations against Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh be probed, that the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) is run by officials who keep the sport clean, and that there's no exploitation of girls and women.

Q. Another narrative doing the rounds is that this is a Thakur vs. Jat battle for control the WFI.

These are tactics to deviate from the real issue—Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh. Initially, they said it was a 'Thakur-Jat' issue, then it became 'Haryana vs. UP', then the narrative was that 'some political party is backing them', and then, 'they [protesters] belong to one family'. It's a means to undermine our protest.

Q. Why did it take so long to speak out? What was the trigger?

Now that all allegations are out and you can see the delay

hands. By April, they knew what they were up against. "We are staking our entire careers, our family names for this. We come from rural backgrounds—speaking of this is not easy," Malik had said, as she and two others, along with Punia's wife Sangeeta, camped at Jantar Mantar, braving unseasonal April rain under a makeshift tarpaulin roof. Every morning, they would try to get in a quick workout on the pavements before returning to their dharna. Initially, all had felt comforted by the presence of a great many other girls. But as the battle stretched on, many, disillusioned, began to leave. "We don't blame them for losing courage. This is not an easy fight. None of us expected the kind of victim-shaming and threats we have got," adds Malik. This is in addition to the fact that the victims are already dealing with the fear and trauma of sexual harassment. "Trauma impacts our nervous system significantly," says trauma psychiatrist Dr Harish Shetty. "It is unreasonable to ask a trauma victim to think through every step clearly and calculatedly. In fact, being unsettled, having lapses in memory, going on adrenalin is a trauma response itself."

The consequences to family reputation and livelihood are not a trifling thing for them. The Balalli village in Haryana's Charkhi Dadri district, whose entry sign proudly bears Vinesh's name, hasn't always stood behind her or her husband Somvir Rathee, or her cousin Sangeeta and her husband Punia, all of whom are part of the protest. In the deeply patriarchal Haryanvi milieu that they come from, it was an enormous struggle for the girls, to begin with, to reach where they have. Their efforts now to speak out against sexual harassment and participate in protest are often seen as going too far. A female wrestler, speaking on condition of anonymity, talks about the socio-cultural backlash they are all facing. "I was at the protest for the first two months and then left because my father dragged me away. At home, he hit me because I had associated myself with this crowd. Not all families are proud of our courage. They think of the family